



# DBDOME

## Grafana User & Dashboard Access Guide

Creating Users & Profiles - Managing Dashboard Permissions

Product: Grafana OSS (open-source) | Audience: Organisation Admins

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This guide explains how a Grafana administrator creates user accounts, assigns each user an access profile (organisation role), and controls which users may view or edit a specific dashboard. The main sections target Grafana OSS 10.x / 11.x; menu names may differ slightly between versions. In Grafana OSS, permissions are additive - the most permissive rule wins and there is no per-user 'deny', so access is restricted by removing broad grants rather than by explicitly blocking a user. Appendices A and B cover the fine-grained Role-Based Access Control (RBAC) available in Grafana Enterprise and paid Grafana Cloud.

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## Before You Begin (SETUP)

*Confirm your access and understand how Grafana decides who can see what.*

### **REQ 1** Sign in with an administrator account

You need a Grafana Server Admin account to create login accounts, and/or an Organisation Admin account to manage roles, teams and dashboard permissions. If you cannot see Administration in the left menu, you do not yet have the required rights.

### **REQ 2** Understand the permission model

Every user has one organisation role - Viewer, Editor or Admin - that sets their baseline access. Dashboard and folder permissions then refine that access for individual users or teams.

### **REQ 3** Remember: permissions are additive

OSS has no per-user 'deny'. A user is kept out of a dashboard by NOT granting access and by removing broad role-based grants - never by an explicit block. Org Admins always retain access by design.

### **TIP** Organise restricted dashboards into folders

Keep dashboards that need controlled access in a dedicated folder and manage permissions at the folder level. Dashboards inherit the folder's permissions, which is far easier to maintain than editing each dashboard individually.



## Create a New User (USER)

*Add a login account so the person can sign in to Grafana.*

### STEP 1 Open user administration

In the left menu choose Administration -> Users and access -> Users. (In older versions this is Server Admin -> Users.)

### STEP 2 Start a new user

Click 'New user'. Alternatively click 'Invite' to email an invitation link - this requires SMTP to be configured on the Grafana server.

### STEP 3 Enter the account details

Provide Name, Email, Username and an initial Password, then click 'Create user'. The account can now sign in.

### STEP 4 Hand over the credentials securely

Share the username and initial password over a secure channel and ask the user to change it on first sign-in via Profile -> Change password.



## Set the User Profile & Access Role (PROFILE)

*A user's profile is their account details plus the organisation role that defines their baseline privileges. Optionally group users into Teams to reuse a common access profile.*

### STEP 1 Open the user record

Go to Administration -> Users and access -> Users and click the user you just created.

### STEP 2 Assign the organisation role (the access profile)

Under 'Organisations', set the role: Viewer = read dashboards only; Editor = create and edit dashboards; Admin = manage the org, users and permissions. This role is the user's baseline profile. Save the change.

### STEP 3 Complete the profile details (optional)

The user maintains their own profile - display name, email, theme, home dashboard, timezone - from the user menu -> Profile. An admin can edit the name and email from the user's admin page.

### STEP 4 Use a Team as a reusable profile (optional)

Go to Administration -> Users and access -> Teams -> 'New team', name it (e.g. 'Finance-Viewers'), open it and add members. You can then grant dashboard access to the whole team at once instead of user by user.



## Enable Dashboard Privilege for One User (GRANT)

*Give a specific user permission to view or edit a particular dashboard or folder.*

### STEP 1 Open the dashboard (or its folder)

From Dashboards, open the dashboard you want to share. To apply the same access to many dashboards, open the folder that contains them instead.

### STEP 2 Open the Permissions screen

For a dashboard: click the settings (gear) icon -> Permissions. For a folder: open the folder and choose the Permissions tab.

### STEP 3 Add the user with a permission level

Click 'Add a permission' -> choose 'User' -> select the user -> set the level: 'View' to let them read it, or 'Edit' to let them change it. Click Save.

### STEP 4 Confirm the grant

The user now appears in the permissions list with their level and will see the dashboard on their next sign-in or refresh. Note: granting 'Edit' on a specific dashboard lets a Viewer edit that one dashboard, even though their org role stays Viewer elsewhere.



## Disable / Remove Dashboard Privilege for Another User (RESTRICT)

*Prevent a user from seeing or editing a dashboard. Because OSS permissions are additive (no explicit deny), you remove the broad access that currently exposes the dashboard and grant it only to the users who should have it.*

### STEP 1 Open the dashboard or folder permissions

Settings (gear) -> Permissions for a dashboard, or the folder's Permissions tab.

### STEP 2 Remove the broad role grants

Delete the default 'Editor' and 'Viewer' role rows using the remove/trash icon. These rows give every Editor/Viewer in the org access; removing them closes the dashboard to 'everyone'.

### STEP 3 Remove the specific user's grant

If the user you want to block has an individual permission row, delete it as well.

### STEP 4 Grant access back to only the allowed users/teams

Add back only the users or teams that should keep access (see the GRANT section). The blocked user, now matching no grant, can no longer open the dashboard.

### STEP 5 Check for indirect access

The user can still get in if they are an Org Admin, a folder/dashboard Admin, or a member of a team that still holds a grant. Verify none of these apply - Org Admins always retain access.



## Verify & Maintain (VERIFY)

*Confirm the result and keep permissions tidy over time.*

### STEP 1 Test as the affected user

Ask the user to sign in (or use a private/incognito window with their account) and confirm they can - or cannot - see the dashboard as intended.

### STEP 2 Review the permissions list

The Permissions screen should show exactly the roles, teams and users you intend, and nothing broader.

### STEP 3 Prefer folder-level management

For ongoing control, set permissions on the folder and let dashboards inherit. Move a dashboard into the correct folder rather than editing each dashboard's permissions.

### STEP 4 Re-check after any role change

Promoting a user to Org Admin grants broad access. Review your restricted folders whenever a user's organisation role changes.



## Appendix A - Enterprise RBAC: Concepts (APPX-A)

*Grafana Enterprise and paid Grafana Cloud add Role-Based Access Control (RBAC) on top of the OSS model, letting you grant precise, action-level permissions through roles instead of relying only on the Viewer / Editor / Admin org roles. Like OSS, RBAC is grant-only: permissions are additive across all of a user's roles and there is no 'deny' rule - you restrict access by granting narrowly, not by blocking.*

### **NOTE 1** Availability and where to manage it

RBAC ships with Grafana Enterprise and paid Grafana Cloud tiers; it is not part of OSS. Manage it under Administration -> Users and access -> Roles, and via the role picker on each user, team or service account.

### **CONCEPT** Three kinds of role

Basic roles - the now-customizable Viewer / Editor / Admin (and Grafana Admin) baselines. Fixed roles - Grafana-supplied roles prefixed 'fixed:' (e.g. fixed:dashboards:reader, fixed:users:writer) that you cannot edit. Custom roles - roles you define with your own chosen set of permissions.

### **CONCEPT** A permission = action + scope

Each permission pairs an action (e.g. dashboards:read, dashboards:write, dashboards.permissions:write) with a scope that limits where it applies (e.g. dashboards:uid:<uid>, folders:uid:<uid>, or dashboards:\* for everything). Narrow scopes are how you keep access tightly contained.

### **CONCEPT** Assign roles to users, teams or service accounts

A role can be attached to an individual user, to a team (so every member inherits it), or to a service account used by automation and API tokens.

### **TIP** Tighten the defaults by editing basic roles

Because RBAC has no deny, the way to reduce what 'everyone' can do is to remove permissions from a basic role - e.g. strip dashboards:create from the Editor basic role so Editors can no longer create dashboards org-wide.

### **TIP** Manage RBAC as code

Beyond the UI, assign roles and permissions through the HTTP API, file-based provisioning, or the Terraform provider for repeatable, reviewable access control across environments.





## Appendix B - RBAC in Practice: Dashboard Access (APPX-B)

*How the 'grant to one user, restrict another' task from the main guide is done with RBAC. The dashboard / folder Permissions screen in Enterprise is backed by RBAC, and you can additionally use custom roles for reusable, scoped access.*

### STEP 1 Grant one user read access to a dashboard

Option A (UI): open the dashboard -> settings -> Permissions -> Add -> User -> View. Under the hood this grants `dashboards:read` scoped to that dashboard's uid. Option B (role): create a custom role with action `dashboards:read` and scope `dashboards:uid:<uid>`, then assign it to the user or their team.

### STEP 2 Give scoped edit rights with a custom role

Create a custom role (e.g. 'Sales Dashboard Editor') containing `dashboards:read` + `dashboards:write` scoped to `folders:uid:<sales-folder-uid>`, and assign it to the user or team. They can edit everything in that folder and nothing else.

### STEP 3 Restrict another user

RBAC has no deny, so restriction means: (a) ensure the user is not granted the action by any role; (b) do not add them on the dashboard's Permissions list; (c) confirm they are not in a team that holds a granting role; and (d) if a basic role is too broad, remove the relevant permission from it. The user then has no path to the dashboard.

### STEP 4 Verify effective access

Use the user's page -> role picker to see every assigned role, or query the RBAC HTTP API to confirm exactly which actions and scopes resolve for that user. Finish by signing in as them to confirm.

### NOTE Precedence recap

Effective access is the union of basic + fixed + custom roles plus any dashboard / folder permissions. If any one of them grants the action on the scope, the user has access - nothing subtracts it.